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SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 1, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

**2026 ELECTION**  
GOVERNOR

## Republican candidates push crime as top issue

Statistics show rates have declined in city and across the country

By Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gorner  
Chicago Tribune

It was four years ago in May that Darren Bailey declared Chicago a “crime-ridden, corrupt, dysfunctional hellhole” as he and five rivals made crime the centerpiece issue in their race to be the Republican nominee for governor.

Based on statements from the four current GOP candidates for governor, including Bailey, who is seeking a second chance, not much has changed.

To be sure, Bailey, the unsuccessful 2022 GOP challenger to Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker, says he is moderating his tone about the city. But he and primary opponents Ted Dabrowski, Rick Heidner and James Mendrick still maintain crime is a top issue of their campaigns — and have recently added their support of Republican President Donald Trump’s aggressive immigration enforcement to the mix.

Yet statistics show that since that 2022 election, violent crime is down in Chicago and across the nation. That’s something even Trump, whom the GOP candidates pledge fealty to, has proclaimed. Just a little more than a week ago, the president declared, “America is safer than it has been in over a century,” as the White House cited data of declining murder rates in the nation’s biggest municipalities.

Trump has taken credit for the falling crime rates, attributing them to his deployment of federal agents to Democratic-run cities, even though Chicago Police Department data show the city ended 2025 with declines in most major crime categories — including murders and shootings — drops that began before Trump started

Turn to Crime, Page 6



People attend a vigil for Alex Pretti outside the Jesse Brown VA Medical Center on Wednesday in Chicago. Federal immigration officers shot and killed Pretti, a 37-year-old VA intensive care unit nurse, on Jan. 24 in Minneapolis. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

## ‘I did not expect it to be worse in another city’

Still reeling from Operation Midway Blitz, Chicago casts wary eye toward Minneapolis

By Caroline Kubzansky and Laura Rodríguez Presa  
Chicago Tribune

Like many Chicago-area residents, Katie Bunt watched in horror as federal agents conducted Operation Midway Blitz in Chicago, and did what she could to push back on the immigration raids as they swept through the city and suburbs. She hadn’t anticipated that immigration enforcement even-

tually would escalate further than it did here.

“Every big action ICE and DHS are taking is a clue to the next place that it could be worse,” Bunt said. “I did not expect it to be worse in another city.”

But on a frigid Tuesday night in Albany Park, Bunt was dropping off bundles of hand warmers at a last-minute supply drive for protesters in Minneapolis, which along with St. Paul has found itself in the crosshairs of the

federal government as it carries out its latest, stepped-up enforcement surge against immigrants without legal status, wreaking much of the same chaos there as agents did here in the fall during Operation Midway Blitz.

Though federal operations in Minnesota have taken place on a different scale than they did here, with thousands more agents overtaking much smaller

Turn to Minneapolis, Page 4

**EXECUTIVE ORDER:** Mayor directs police to investigate federal agents for possible felony charges. **Chicagoland, Page 5**

**BROOKFIELD INCIDENT:** Body camera footage sheds light on agent’s confrontation with protester. **Chicagoland, Page 6**

**ICE MEMO:** Federal agents were told last week they have broader power to arrest people without a warrant. **Nation & World**

## Stricter ballast rules demanded on lake freighters

Higher standards would protect Great Lakes from invasive species

By Jerry Wu  
Chicago Tribune

To prevent further spread of potentially catastrophic invasive species in the Great Lakes, the Canadian government is moving forward with tighter restrictions on all freighters. But standards finalized by the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency in 2024, meanwhile, apply only to a fraction of the lake-going vessels.

Environmentalists say the U.S. standards are flawed because existing lakers — or ships that stay within the Great Lakes — are exempted, and new lakers are rarely built.

“They suck all those zebra mussels up in them, along with

the lake water from one location when they’re doing that uptake, and then they’re going to a new location, and they let them out,” said Wendy Bloom, a lawyer with the Environmental Law and Policy Center. “They’ve now created a new location infested with those species.”

While ballast discharge regulations have been in place since 2008 for ocean-going freighters, known as salties, few such rules exist for lakers.

In December, the law and policy center and three other environmental groups filed a petition in D.C.’s U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals calling on the EPA to include existing freighters in all of the new standards, arguing that lax regulations have contributed to the spread of invasive species nationwide.

Turn to Freighters, Page 2



The Illinois International Port District facility on the Calumet River at Lake Michigan on July 18, 2023, in Chicago. In the United States, the EPA’s regulations only require “lakers” built in the future and ocean-going freighters to install treatment systems that will remove and kill foreign organisms in ballast water. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

## A spark is kindled on the South Side

Anticipation grows for new White Sox slugger Munetaka Murakami. Players at SoxFest say it’s time to believe. **Chicago Sports**

### TODAY’S WEATHER

High 27  
Low 20



Complete Chicagoland forecast on Opinion Page 12

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